

Intxaur Saltsa (Walnut Cream)

Intxaur is "walnut" in Euskara, and this walnut cream is one of the most ancient desserts in the Basque repertoire. Walnuts, crushed in a mortar or pulverized with a rolling pin or wine bottle, were sprinkled into a pot of steaming milk, hanging over an open fire. They were left to stew down into a creamy mush, perhaps with a bit of egg or bread crumbs thrown in to thicken the mixture. The result was a delicious, creamy pudding.

Intxaur saltsa has only recently begun to reappear on restaurant menus, in a self-consciously retro nod with patriotic undertones. It is a dish made with ingredients available around the baserri, walnuts from the ground and milk from the cows, so it's rustic and without pretensions. This version is straightforward yet can be quite elegant, a surprising dessert that is simple and healthy. Walnuts from Basque Country are a revelation—plump, with a flavor that makes them seem more fruit than nut—so toasting them would be overkill. However, if top-quality, fresh walnuts aren't available where you are, you can toast the walnuts before grinding them to bring out their flavor. The size of the pieces is a matter of personal taste, but a mixture of powdery and crumblike bits is best.

Serves 4

Ingredients

- **4 cups (960 mL)** whole milk
 - **1** cinnamon stick
 - **2 cups (250 g)** top-quality shelled walnuts, plus more for garnish (see headnote)
 - **¾ cup (150 g)** sugar
-

Instructions

1. **Infuse the Milk:** Place the milk and the cinnamon stick in a saucepan. Heat over high heat until the milk is steaming. Just before it starts to simmer, remove from the heat and set aside to infuse for at least 10 minutes.
2. **Prepare the Walnuts:** Meanwhile, chop or crush the walnuts very finely by putting them in a clean kitchen towel and rolling them repeatedly with a rolling pin or by pulsing them in a food processor, but be careful not to overprocess. There should be a mixture of powdery and small, crumblike pieces. The powdery pieces will thicken the mixture; the crumblike pieces will give it a pleasant texture.
3. **Cook the Pudding:** Add the sugar and walnuts to the milk. Return the pot to high heat and bring the mixture to a very gentle simmer. Lower the temperature to medium and cook, maintaining a gentle simmer and stirring often, until the pudding has a creamy texture, about 30 minutes.
4. **Cool and Serve:** Let cool to room temperature, or chill and eat cold. Garnish with extra nuts, if desired.